Core Buildup (D2950) Attachment Checklist

Know exactly what to document and attach before you submit

D2950 is one of the most frequently denied restorative codes because payers read it as duplicate work on a tooth that already has a crown claim. This checklist removes that argument before it starts.

1. Confirm the buildup is separately billable

- [ ] Check the payer's policy: some plans include core buildup in the crown fee and will never pay D2950 separately.
- [ ] Confirm the tooth needed the buildup to retain the crown, not simply to replace an existing restoration.
- [ ] Verify whether the plan requires amputation (D2955) language instead of, or in addition to, D2950.
- [ ] If the plan bundles it, decide the patient estimate before treatment rather than after the denial.

2. Documentation that survives review

- [ ] Note states how much sound tooth structure remained at the gingival margin.
- [ ] Note describes the material used and why a buildup was clinically necessary.
- [ ] Pre-op radiograph shows the remaining tooth structure and the margin.
- [ ] Clinical photo taken after caries removal and before the buildup.
- [ ] Tooth number appears in the note and matches the claim line exactly.

3. Code and date alignment

- [ ] D2950 is on the same date of service as the crown, or the note explains the split.
- [ ] Surfaces billed for the buildup do not overlap with surfaces billed for the crown restoration.
- [ ] No D2950 on a tooth that already had a buildup billed within the payer's replacement window.
- [ ] If the buildup was placed by another provider, that provider's NPI is on the claim line.

4. Attachment packet

- [ ] Cover page naming the tooth, the codes submitted and the reason for the buildup.
- [ ] Before-and-after photos, dated.
- [ ] Radiograph with the date of exposure visible.

- [ ] Narrative written in clinical language, not billing language.

5. If it denies

- [ ] Read the denial code before writing the appeal; bundled, not covered and insufficient documentation need different responses.
- [ ] For a bundling denial, cite the plan's own coverage language if it lists D2950 as a payable service.
- [ ] For documentation denial, resend the missing item with the original claim number on every page.
- [ ] Log the denial reason so the next core buildup on this payer is submitted correctly the first time.

Bottom line: Track D2950 denials by payer for one quarter. The pattern tells you which plans bundle it, and that answer belongs in your patient estimate, not in an appeal.